in India', marked the beginning of 'women's studies in India' and a 'radically altered perspective on the women's questions for activists, the State and researchers alike'.[41]

The creation of the Mahila Morcha in 1980 was thus the BJP's response to a major debate in India at the time on the status of women. Morcha workers welcomed Vajpayee to their enclosure with the slogan '*Ham Bharat ki naari hain, phool nahin chingari hain* [We are the women of India. We are not flowers, we are embers].' The feminist historian Tanika Sarkar heard this 'beautifully feminist slogan' being chanted by women karsevikas in Ayodhya a decade later.[42] The foundation for that mobilisation too was laid with the creation of the Mahila Morcha.

The Morcha's first resolution, titled 'Equal Rights & Equal Dignity for Women' and adopted in that 1980 Bombay meeting, had six demands: 'free education for women of families with incomes within Income Tax limits', more stringent anti-dowry laws, trial of rape cases before 'lady judges in camera', 'Equal Pay for Equal Work', 'Justice and social security for divorcee women' and education to diminish the impact of caste and untouchability on women.[43] These were progressive, forward-looking demands which echoed—at least in theory—the broader thrust of India's rising feminist movement. Yet, the low representation of women at senior levels, an inability to go beyond the party's core constituencies and the failure to give prominence to women's issues in its wider politics meant that the initiative did not immediately gain traction.

The BJP's first National Executive in 1980 had only five (4.7 per cent) women members, out of a total 106 members who were listed in the party's apex body.[44] The social profiles of these five original women members of the National Executive, who made up a tiny minority in the party's initial leadership, showcased the origins of BJP's initial women cohort. Rajmata Scindia, the dowager queen of the princely state of Gwalior, was a major party patron from Madhya Pradesh. Initially a Congress MP from Guna,[45] she switched to the Swatantra Party and finally to the Jan Sangh in 1967.[46] She played a big part in the downfall of the Madhya Pradesh Congress government in 1967 and became the leader of the Samyukta